guarantee future progress. The usual concern only relates to the 'digital have-nots'. But those alive to long-term trends in mental health also see a lengthening shadow in the data. The internet hasn't been around long enough for there to be multi-generational studies on its effects on cognition, but the longitudinal studies that exist paint a grey picture.

A GLOBAL CONCERN

Neither state has spelled out the exact method or model it will adopt, but both are responding to a gradually building global groundswell. In December 2025, Australia became the first country to ban platforms like Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, X, Reddit and YouTube for under-16s. The platforms stand liable for heavy penalties in case of non-compliance. Since then, Denmark, Britain, France, Spain and a clutch of other nations are either mulling restrictions or have set them in motion. One method in vogue includes China's daily cap on usage and a 10 pm-6 am smartphone curfew for minors, introduced in 2023.

"I don't think we can ban it in its entirety, but somebody should take the onus on regulating it... content, age verification et al," Karnataka's IT minister Priyank Kharge told INDIA TODAY. "The idea is to involve all stakeholders: academic institutions, the legal fraternity, technologists and media platforms to understand where we stand in all this." Karnataka, he says, is setting up task-force committees with a two-pronged intent: to advise on the responsible use of artificial intelligence in governance, as well as social media regulation.

Peer recommendations and FOMO (fear of missing out) are a big factor in forming internet gaming or social media habits, explains Dr Manoj Kumar Sharma, head of the SHUT Clinic at Bengaluru's National Institute of Mental Health and Neurosciences (NIMHANS). The teasing acronym 'SHUT' sounds more liberal when filled out—it stands for 'Service for Healthy Use of Technology'. The clinic offers specialised psychological treatments for internet addiction amongst children and runs an online support group for parents. "Most parents are concerned because they find a change in the lifestyle of the child... irregular sleeping habits, low physical activity, becoming isolated," says Dr Sharma. "Their main problem is negotiation on how much is too much. They don't know how to, or can't negotiate, for device usage and screen time." The World Health Organization (WHO) stipulates screentime limited to an hour for under-10s and not more than two hours for the 11-17 age group.



"We can't ban social media entirely, but someone should regulate it. We don't want a knee-jerk move to send children to unregulated social media"

PRIYANK KHARGE
Karnataka IT Minister

It turns out adults, too, might require handholding on that front. Sharma says a recent study by SHUT found screentime among adults ranged between eight and 12 hours, if one also takes into account work-related usage. "So, we have to work with the adults' pattern of use also if we have to promote healthy use in children." Parent mediation, he adds, needs a strengthening of communication within the family so that children can open up about issues such as cyber-bullying or inappropriate content.

"All societies agree there is some age below which children need to be supervised in their use of online spaces," says Rahul Matthan, partner at Bengaluru-based law firm Trilegal, who specialises in technology law. The recently-notified Digital Personal Data Protection Rules, 2025, require verifiable consent from a parent or guardian where a child's personal data is involved. In that light, Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh appear only to be taking the next step.

Verifying the user's age on social media remains a challenge. Matthan reckons India is better placed than others to find a technology fix for this. "No other country has digital identity at scale like we have," he says, suggesting that the date signifier in the Aadhaar number be converted into a digital token for age verification while safeguarding privacy. "You just have to say if the person is above 16 or below. You do not unnecessarily identify a person," he says.

CAREFUL STEPS

But other bridges must be crossed first. One is purely legal-technical. Social media falls within the national jurisdiction and it's not clear if states can legislate on it, though education—and thereby regulation of phones in schools—come within their purview.

"There is a bit of ambiguity in that," Kharge concedes, adding that's why Karnataka's discussions on the proposed regulation will involve all stakeholders, including the legal experts. Besides, he says it is important to 'tread cautiously' given that it's a new and unfamiliar territory globally. "We don't want some kind of knee-jerk reaction that will send children to unregulated social media," Kharge adds.

Since it's India's two most experienced states on IT that have taken the first step, the conversation will hopefully soon go national. ■

Takeaways

- **The CMs of Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh propose social media ban for kids**
- **Age-based curbs are a global trend: Australia has moved, others are mulling**